

1937-

MILESTONES

SPACE RACE

Enters Soviet space program in 1961, during the politically motivated "space race" with rival US.

FEMALE COSMONAUT

Makes history as the first woman in space in 1963—the next woman would not reach space until 1984.

STELLAR CAREER

Becomes director of Soviet Women's Committee in 1968 and member of the Supreme Soviet Presidium in 1974.

Valentina Tereshkova is a Soviet cosmonaut and engineer who in 1963 became the first woman and the first civilian to fly in space.

After leaving school at age 16, Valentina Tereshkova worked in a textile factory and took up parachute jumping. Following the early Soviet victory over the US in the "space race"—achieved by sending the first man into space—she volunteered for the Soviet space program in 1961. After 16 months of training, in which she was exposed to extreme isolation and zero-gravity conditions, Tereshkova became the first woman to fly in space. She was launched in the space capsule Vostok 6 on June 16, 1963, and completed 48 orbits of Earth during 71 hours of flying. She never flew in space again but was made a Hero of the Soviet Union in 1966 and gained a doctorate in engineering in 1977.

Being an amateur parachuter helped Tereshkova as a cosmonaut, as she had to parachute from the capsule Vostok 6 on the return journey back to Earth.

VALENTINA

TERESHKOVA

